

Ballet

Ballet started as an entertainment in the royal courts of Europe, and has grown into a breathtaking art form, enjoyed all over the world. Professional dancers work hard to reach the highest levels of fitness and artistry.

1547
Italian Catherine de Medici becomes queen of France and brings an Italian style of dancing to the French court.



Catherine de Medici

1661
First dance institution set up in Paris – l'Académie Royale de Danse.

1680
King Louis XIV starts staging regular operaballets at Versailles.



Palace of Versailles

1841
First performance of *Giselle*, danced by Italian ballerina Carlotta Grisi, takes place in Paris.

1877
Swan Lake, with music by Tchaikovsky, is performed by the Bolshoi Ballet in Moscow, Russia.

1913
The Rite of Spring, choreographed by Vaslav Nijinsky, causes outrage at its premiere in Paris.

1964
Dancers Margot Fonteyn and Rudolf Nureyev receive a record 89 curtain calls after performing *Swan Lake* in Vienna, Austria.

1500

THE STORY OF BALLET

Ballet developed in France, which is why all the steps still have French names. It became a huge attraction in the great theatres of France, Italy, Russia, Scandinavia, and England.

1653
King Louis XIV dances the role of Apollo, the Sun god, in *Le Ballet de la Nuit* (The Dance of the Night).



Statue of Louis XIV of France

1669
Dancer and director Pierre Beauchamps develops the five basic positions of the feet and arms.



Third position

1738
Imperial Russian Ballet School is founded in St Petersburg, Russia.

1832
La Sylphide, choreographed by Filippo Taglioni, opens in Paris, France.



Mariinsky Theatre, home of the Russian Imperial Ballet from 1860

1890
The premiere of *Sleeping Beauty* is performed at the Mariinsky Theatre, St Petersburg.

1909
Ballet impresario, or organizer, Sergei Diaghilev forms the *Ballets Russes* company in Paris.

1931
The Sadler's Wells Ballet (renamed the Royal Ballet in 1959) is formed in London.



Sculpture outside the Royal Opera House, home of the Royal Ballet

YEARS OF TRAINING

Most professional dancers start young. After 8–10 years of dedicated training, only a few of the most talented students will join a ballet company (*corps de ballet*). The best dancers might progress to become a soloist or principal dancer.



BEGINNER
Dancers begin around age five, taking classes at a local studio.



BALLET SCHOOL
At the age of 11, the dancer is accepted at a ballet school.



APPRENTICE
At 16, the most promising students go on to three more years' study.



CORPS DE BALLET
The dancer joins a company, then progresses to minor roles.



PRINCIPAL
At this highest rank a dancer performs all the leading roles.

MAKING A POINTE SHOE

Female dancers wear special reinforced shoes so they can dance on the tips of their toes, a technique called *en pointe*. Dancers often embroider the toe area, to make shoes last longer and to help prevent slipping.



1 SHAPING THE UPPER
Layers of satin and stiff canvas are stitched together.



2 ADDING TOE BLOCKS
A leather sole is inserted, then layers of card, paper, and stiff fabric are pasted around the toe area to form a block.



3 SHAPING THE SHOE
The sole is stitched to the upper with thread. The shoe is then shaped with a special hammer.



4 ADDING RIBBONS
Traditionally, a dancer sews the ribbons on to her shoes herself.

CLASSIC BALLET

The fashion for full-length ballets reached its height at the end of the 19th century. Many of the ballets from that time are still popular today.

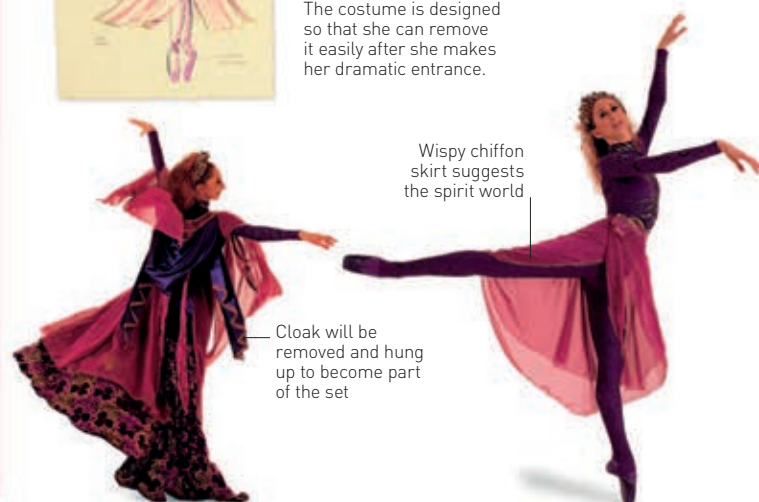
- **SWAN LAKE, 1877**
A handsome prince falls in love with a mysterious girl, only to discover that an evil magician has cast a spell on her.
- **GISELLE, 1841, ADAPTED 1884**
A young girl is betrayed by the man she loves. She dies of grief, then comes back as a ghost and saves the life of the man who broke her heart.
- **THE FIREBIRD, 1910**
Based on several Russian folk tales, it tells the story of how Prince Ivan and the magical Firebird overcome an evil magician called Kostchée.
- **COPPELIA, 1871**
A light-hearted tale of a young man who falls for a life-sized doll, before realizing that his true love is the real, live girl next door.
- **THE NUTCRACKER, 1891**
Toys magically come to life and take their owner on a journey to the Kingdom of Sweets, where the Sugar Plum Fairy lives, in this Christmas story.

COSTUME DESIGN

Costumes tell the audience about a character but must also allow a dancer to move freely. Below is the costume for a character from Greek myth called Eurydice, who is taken to the gloomy Underworld when she dies.



FROM SKETCHPAD TO STAGE
When Eurydice first appears, she is weighed down by a heavy cloak. The costume is designed so that she can remove it easily after she makes her dramatic entrance.



Wispy chiffon skirt suggests the spirit world

Cloak will be removed and hung up to become part of the set

ONLY MEN PERFORMED BALLET UNTIL 1681, WHEN MADEMOISELLE DE LAFONTAINE BECAME THE FIRST BALLERINA